Managing these fault lines raised a contentious issue within the G20 about how transparent it should be about these differences. A large majority of the G20 members felt that these differences, if exposed, would be exaggerated in the global media which would dent the credibility of the G20, spook the markets and undermine the as-yet fragile recovery from the crisis. They would contend that these differences should remain within the conference room and we should all present a picture of unity to the outside world, much like the code of conduct of collective Cabinet responsibility in a parliamentary system. Ranged against this was a minority view that any such cover-up attempt would be pretentious. Differences, they argued, are inevitable in a world divided by nation states with no natural constituency for the global economy. There was no need, therefore, to be secretive about them. Besides, being upfront about differences of views would help the G20 get larger public inputs into global policy issues and give us a more informed basis for decision-making.

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The G20 meetings typically started with an extended working dinner hosted by the chair country which provided an informal, freewheeling discussion on the global economy. That would be followed by the formal full-day meeting the following day.

The last item on the agenda would be approving the communiqué of the meeting. The communiqué process itself was quite interesting. It was not that someone sitting in the meeting drafts the communiqué on the basis of the discussion there. In fact, a draft communiqué, based on the agenda, is circulated to the members in advance of the meeting. Even as the G20 meeting is in progress, the deputies of the G20 delegations convene in a parallel session negotiating the draft communiqué regularly, but informally, checking with their respective principals on the content as well as the nuancing and messaging. This process ensured that a pre-final draft of the communiqué was available to the G20 delegates as soon as they completed the agenda of the meeting.